SAINT PETERSBURG, RUSSIA

State Hermitage Museum: Masterpieces

Handclasps, embraces, glances and gaps organise relationships across twenty selected works.



In Matisse's *Dance*, a gap between reaching hands keeps the ring from becoming a finished pattern. In *Music*, separate bodies belong together without touching at all. The two paintings offer a particularly clear comparison of how a group can be constructed. Earlier works in this selection make relationships through subtler means: an infant reaching for a book, a woman extending her hand towards unseen light, or a child looking out from an embrace.

Follow these connections before treating a picture as a set of individual figures. The spaces between bodies can be as consequential as their expressions. This approach also makes comparison possible across styles without pretending that resemblance establishes direct influence.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/hermitage

The selection · 20

1. Danaë
   Rembrandt van Rijn · 1643
2. The Lute Player
   Caravaggio · 1596
3. Dance II
   Henri Matisse · 1910
4. Music
   Henri Matisse · 1910
5. Madonna Litta
   Leonardo da Vinci · 1490
6. The Conestabile Madonna
   Raphael · 1502
7. Madonna and Child before a Fireplace
   Robert Campin · 1430
8. Place de la Concorde
   Edgar Degas · 1875
9. Blue Landscape
   Paul Cézanne · 1903
10. A Group of Cottages
    Vincent van Gogh · 1890
11. Landscape with a House and Ploughman
    Vincent van Gogh · 1889
12. Breakfast
    Diego Velázquez · c. 1618
13. David and Uriah
    Rembrandt van Rijn · 1665
14. Family Portrait
    Anthony van Dyck · 1621
15. Baroness Anna Stroganova and Her Son Sergey
    Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun · 1793
16. House in a Garden
    Pablo Picasso · 1908
17. Zorah Standing
    Henri Matisse · 1912
18. Dishes and Fruit
    Henri Matisse · 1901
19. Madonna and Child in a Landscape
    Giorgione · 1504
20. Bathing
    Pablo Picasso · 1908

01 / 20

Danaë

Rembrandt van Rijn

1643 · State Hermitage Museum



Rembrandt van Rijn. Danae. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The extended hand reaches towards light rather than a fully depicted visitor. Rembrandt gives the mythological encounter a visible expectation while leaving its other participant outside the immediate scene. Heavy curtains enclose the bed, but the turning body opens that enclosure. The relationship is established through response, before the cause of the response has been completely shown.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

The Lute Player

Caravaggio

1596 · State Hermitage Museum



Caravaggio. The Lute Player. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The open score, flowers and fruit occupy the near space before the musician. Caravaggio gives the performance a material setting, with music, food and growing things sharing the same limited space. The lute's rounded form and bright shirt bring the player close, while the objects retain separate claims on attention. The picture assembles a moment whose elements will not all last equally long.

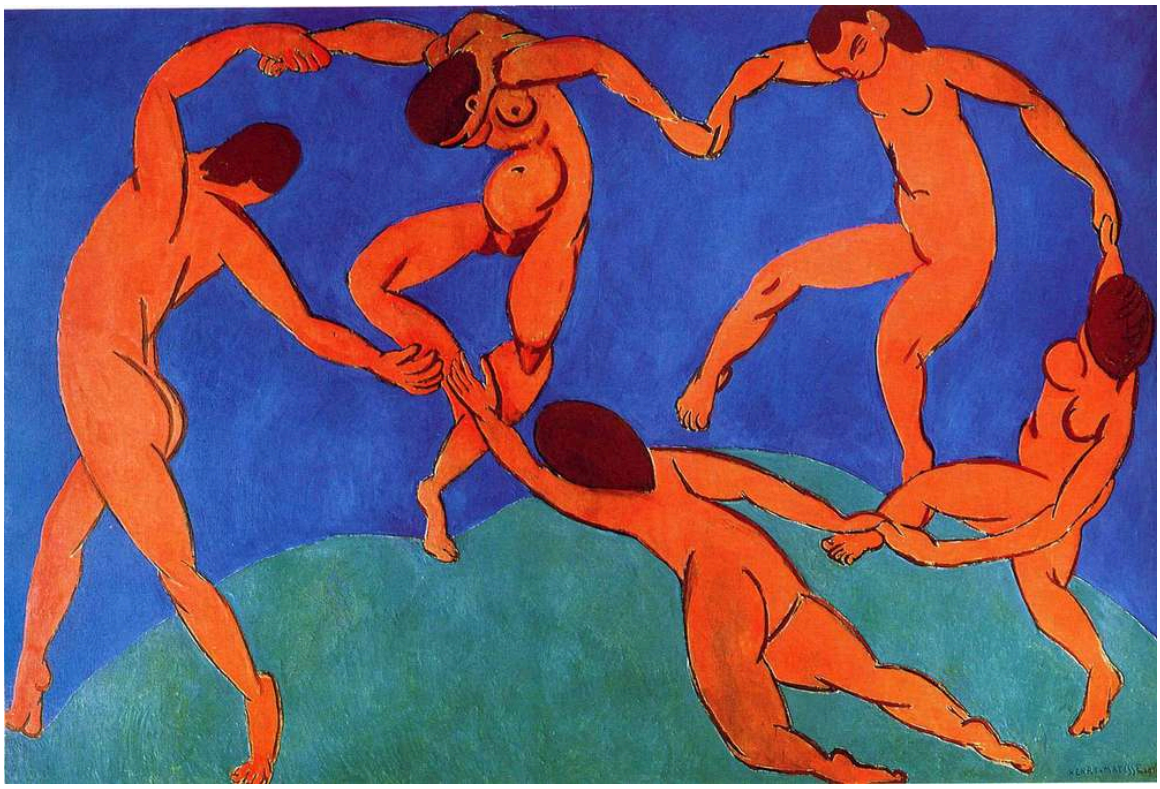
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Dance II

Henri Matisse

1910 · State Hermitage Museum



Henri Matisse. Dance (II). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/henri-matisse/dance-ii-1910 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Five figures make a ring, but the reaching hands leave a visible interruption. That gap turns connection into an effort still being made. Matisse reduces the setting to green ground and blue sky, so the red-orange bodies carry the action without a surrounding story. The circle remains dynamic because its closure is not completely secure.

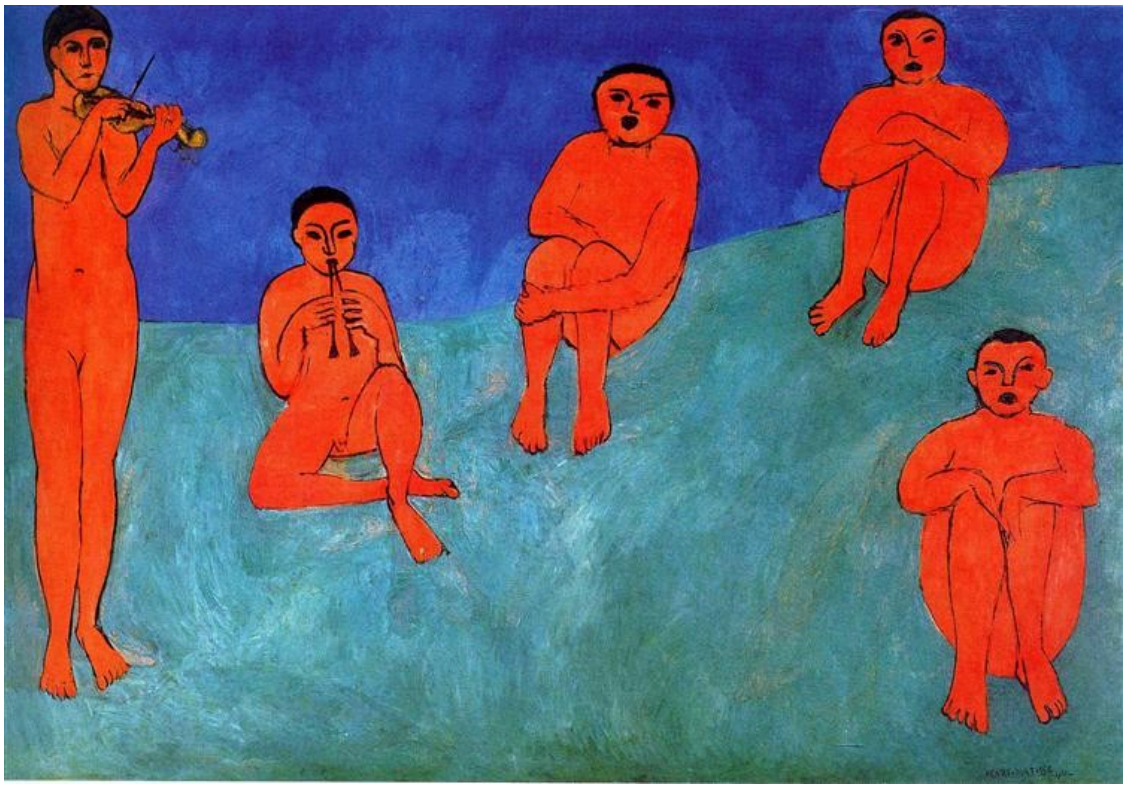
Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Music

Henri Matisse

1910 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Music. WikiArt; Henri Matisse. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Open intervals separate the figures. Repeated red bodies and measured spacing establish a collective activity across the green and blue setting. Compare *Dance*, its companion painting: togetherness need not take the form of continuous touch. Here distinct poses and instruments keep the participants individually legible within an equally reduced pictorial world.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Madonna Litta

Leonardo da Vinci

1490 · State Hermitage Museum



Leonardo da Vinci. Madonna Litta (Madonna and the Child). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Mary's lowered head and the child's body form a close group before two openings onto distant blue. The Hermitage presents the painting as Leonardo's, while other scholarship assigns a larger role to his workshop; the attribution remains disputed. The nursing relationship is organised through joined contours and a clear separation from the landscape beyond.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Conestabile Madonna

Raphael

1502 · State Hermitage Museum



Raphael. The Madonna Conestabile. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The child's reach towards the book gives the pair a shared object of attention. Raphael fits that small action inside a circular field without making the bodies rigidly symmetrical. Curves connect the figures to the boundary, while the landscape continues around them. The format shapes the composition all the way from its outer edge to the child's reaching hand.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

Madonna and Child before a Fireplace

Robert Campin

1430 · Oil on panel · State Hermitage Museum



Robert Campin. Madonna and Child Before a Fireplace. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/robert-campin/madonna-and-child-before-a-fireplace-1430 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The fire, window and small fittings establish a room that could support ordinary daily activity. Campin places the sacred pair within those material particulars while keeping their close relationship distinct. The household setting does not have to become mere background symbolism. Its furnishings also make the space usable, bringing the devotional encounter into a comprehensible interior.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Place de la Concorde

Edgar Degas

1875 · State Hermitage Museum



Edgar Degas. Place de la Concorde. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Bodies cross near the edge of a broad square, and the frame cuts some of them abruptly. Degas refuses the stable enclosure expected of a conventional family group. The man's, girls' and dog's unequal positions make the encounter feel contingent. Public space continues around them instead of being arranged solely to contain their relationship.

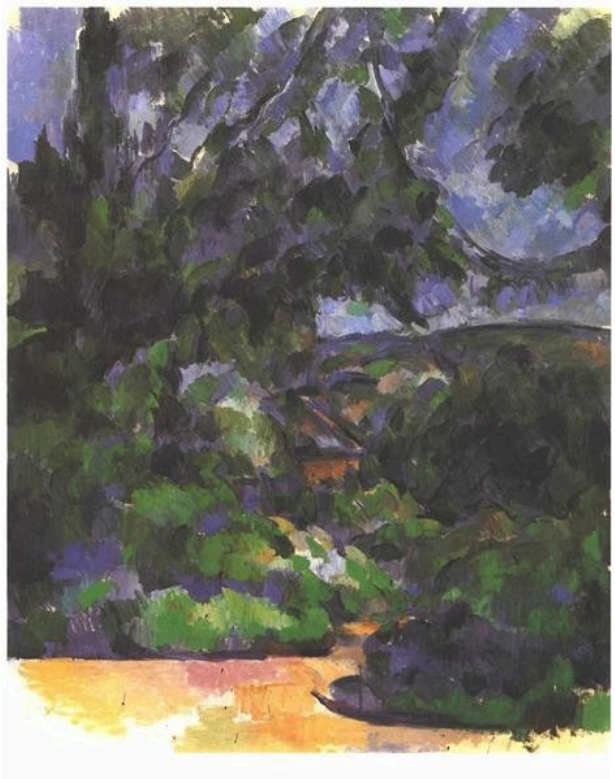
Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Blue Landscape

Paul Cézanne

1903 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Blue Landscape. WikiArt; Paul Cézanne. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Blue and violet foliage gathers around a lighter opening, with buildings and terrain only partly resolved. Relationships among colour patches make Cézanne's landscape readable even where outlines fall away. The eye has to decide where one mass ends and another distance begins. Surface and depicted space remain visible as competing but connected organisations.

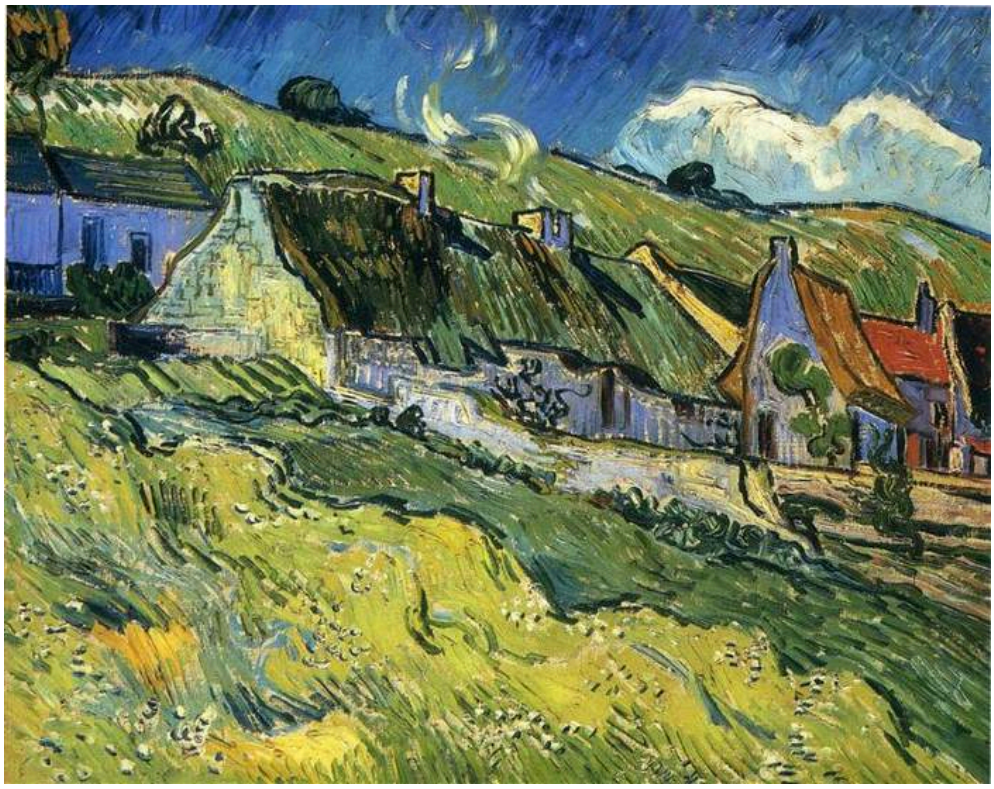
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

A Group of Cottages

Vincent van Gogh

1890 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



A Group of Cottages. WikiArt; Vincent van Gogh. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Strokes change direction as they pass from roofs to walls and foreground field. Van Gogh makes the clustered houses structurally distinct while keeping the whole surface active. Each material receives its own pattern of marks. The village therefore holds together through brushwork whose visible differences also explain the forms it builds.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Landscape with a House and Ploughman

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · State Hermitage Museum



Vincent van Gogh. Landscape with House and Ploughman. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The small worker gives the cultivated slopes a human measure without becoming their visual centre. Yellow and red bands carry attention across land shaped by agricultural use. Van Gogh makes labour part of the landscape's larger organisation. The ploughman matters partly because the ground extends so far beyond the body occupied with working it.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Breakfast

Diego Velázquez

c. 1618 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Diego Velázquez. Breakfast. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/diego-velazquez/breakfast · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The raised vessel links a standing figure to the two men at the table. Velázquez gives bread, containers and cloth a role in serving and eating. Gestures turn the meal into a coordinated activity. The objects explain what the group can do together within a closely bounded space, carrying attention between the standing body and the seated pair.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

David and Uriah

Rembrandt van Rijn

1665 · Oil · State Hermitage Museum



David and Uriah. WikiArt; Rembrandt van Rijn. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

One richly dressed figure receives light while another remains less available in shadow. The hand against the chest makes a restrained gesture carry substantial attention. Rembrandt supplies a tense encounter without showing every stage of the named story. The unequal visibility is worth retaining as a question rather than filling it with a confident account of each participant's thoughts.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

Family Portrait

Anthony van Dyck

1621 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Family Portrait. WikiArt; Anthony van Dyck. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The adults lean towards the child, giving family connection a physical shape. Van Dyck varies the heights of the heads and the direction of their attention. Pale hands and collars clarify the contact within dark clothing. The different expressions remain readable within the group, whose coherence comes from these inclinations and points of contact.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Baroness Anna Stroganova and Her Son Sergey

Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun

1793 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Élisabeth Vigée Le Brun. Baroness Anna Sergeevna Stroganova and Her Son Sergey. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/louise-elisabeth-vigee-le-brun/baroness-anna-sergeevna-stroganova-and-her-son-sergey-1793 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The child's outward look opens the mother's embrace towards the viewer. Vigée Le Brun keeps the pair physically close while permitting that second direction of attention. Warm clothing separates them from the darker landscape, making an intimate act part of a social portrait. The image stages affection without requiring it to explain every aspect of the sitters' relationship.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

House in a Garden

Pablo Picasso

1908 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Pablo Picasso. House in a Garden. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/house-in-a-garden-1908 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Walls, roofs and tree forms interlock within a compressed space. Picasso leaves enough architectural information for a house to remain recognisable while making its boundaries cooperate with the vegetation around it. The garden no longer serves as a loose setting for a separate building. Both participate in the same organisation of angular masses across the surface.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

Zorah Standing

Henri Matisse

1912 · State Hermitage Museum



Henri Matisse. Zorah Standing. Image credit: Henri Matisse. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The narrow frontal figure occupies most of the vertical field, with hands gathered near the waist. Matisse makes the silhouette and repeated ornament carry a strong relationship between body and garment. In the monochrome reproduction used here, those patterns remain readable; the painting's colour relationships do not. It is better to preserve that limit than describe hues the image cannot show.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: ГЭ-10044

18 / 20

Dishes and Fruit

Henri Matisse

1901 · State Hermitage Museum



Henri Matisse. Dishes and Fruit. WikiArt: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt per-object label)

Some objects tilt towards the viewer instead of submitting to one stable tabletop perspective. Matisse uses that adjustment to keep dishes, fruit and patterned cloth active together. Their relationships depend on colour and repeated shapes as well as depth. The still life can be coherent without pretending that every object has been seen from exactly the same position.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: ГЭ-7697

19 / 20

Madonna and Child in a Landscape

Giorgione

1504 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Madonna and Child in a Landscape. WikiArt; Giorgione. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The red and green clothing anchors the close pair before a landscape of rock, buildings and distant mountains. In this work associated with Giorgione, the terrain has a reach and complexity of its own beyond the devotional group. The contrast of scales matters: a small act of support belongs within a world whose extent does not depend on it.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Bathing

Pablo Picasso

1908 · Oil on canvas · State Hermitage Museum



Pablo Picasso. Bathing. WikiArt source label: Public domain US. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pablo-picasso/bathing-1908 · Public domain US (WikiArt source label)

Broad curves and sharp joints give the two bodies a recognisable activity while changing the anatomy through which it is shown. Picasso leaves little open interval around them, so surrounding forms remain closely involved. The scene does not provide a smoothly continuous place. Bodily recognition persists through the turns and actions even where conventional spatial reassurance has been withdrawn.

Object source · Open artwork

Compare contact and distance

Return to *Dance* after a family portrait and compare what a handclasp or embrace actually connects. Similar gestures can serve quite different pictures. The Hermitage's holdings occupy more than one building and works may move; use current museum information to establish location and display rather than treating this selection as a single-room itinerary.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s notes on gesture, light and the body provide questions to bring to the earlier paintings here. Compare those concerns with the much more reduced bodies of Matisse, without treating the book as an explanation for every work.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

Artline · State Hermitage Museum: Masterpieces